



SIPHA DAS

vote for you? It is not just that the Congress is wary of falling into the mood trap that NDA fell victim to when, swept by pink paper euphoria, it called for early polls. Sonia is aware of the pitfalls of the feel good factor. In the days preceding the 2004 polls, she had spent some time with linguists trying to understand how this strange phenomenon called "the feel good factor" would

an idea, the Congress is in a better position to work its game-plan. There are still some pieces missing: the plan of action in Uttar Pradesh, the Paswan puzzle in Bihar and dealing with the Left in West Bengal. These states account for over 164 of the 542 Lok Sabha seats. After the Budget, Congressmen are willing to believe that this too will be cracked in the next few weeks.



MANDAR DEODHAR

In poll mode, the prime minister told Parliament that "we will not stop till we have wiped the tears from all farmers". When Advani questioned him about the funding for the waiver, he retorted, "We have picked up the unpaid distress bill which NDA left behind." Clearly, Manmohan has come a long way from his puritanical ways of the '90s. In a recently released book, he is quoted as telling the



DR PRATHAP C. REDDY, CHAIRMAN, APOLLO GROUP OF HOSPITALS

“With health care being recognised as a priority sector, the common man's access to quality healthcare will improve.”

dle-class woes about high interest rates and predicted food grain shortages.

In preparatory mode, Sonia has been meeting groups of Congress MPs from various states and asking them to educate the *aam aadmi* about the various initiatives taken by the Government. At Rahul's initiative, the party has brought out pamphlets with bullet points explaining the party's stand on controversial issues like the Sethu Samudram and reservations, to help Congressmen educate the public.

Rahul and Sonia may not have a magic wand, but have learnt a valuable lesson from BJP's India Shining fiasco—that announcing schemes without adequate marketing is like winking in the dark. If the *aam aadmi* does not know what you are doing for him, how will he

be translated into Indian languages. In Hindi, she found it meant "*khush fahmi*", which, translated back, means illusion of happiness. Besides, the devil in the execution of any great idea is in the details. The party wants to use the immediate weeks to be sure of the execution and its impact before it takes a call on when to face the electorate.

It does help that the Budget has not just created positive vibes but also helped cement the growing cracks within the alliance. For instance, DMK chief M. Karunanidhi, himself a beneficiary of a major sop opera that brought his party to power, was worried about the optics of being seen as a member of the pro-rich gallery. Now, with all the allies rallying around

audience at a World Bank seminar, "The issue is not so much if the price is right as whether the politics is right." It is not just he who now has a new view on the arithmetic of politics. On March 3, in an interaction with industry at FICCI, Chidambaram was asked why he had not given a 10-year tax holiday to hospitals instead of five years. In his element, he replied, "I wish my Parliament term was for 10 years, but it is not." Chidambaram may not have said it, but his colleagues believe that his Budget should get them the five-year extension in the House.

The next few weeks will see more action on electoral arithmetic as the Congress explores new ideas and firms up alliances for its autumn sonata.

with Shyam Lal Yadav and bureau inputs

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